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The Rise of Bhindranwale (1980–81)

WITH BHINDRANWALE'S capability and willingness to deliver results already tested at the state level, following the Congress party's return to power at the Centre in 1980, it was decided that the Congress would deploy him and the issue of Khalistan – which had by then stuck to him because of his refusal or inability to rebut it – in order to win the eighth Lok Sabha elections that were due before January 1985. This would mark the beginning of the Op-2 phase. Based on my operational experience of working in the Department, certain decisions that came to my notice and developments as they unfolded, the idea behind Op-2 can be summed up as follows:

Create a climate of communal mistrust between Hindus and Sikhs in Punjab and the neighbouring state of Haryana, first by encouraging and then by overlooking acts of violence and extremism attributed to Bhindranwale. This would be accompanied by coverage of related incidents by an obliging media, specially the vernacular press. Also, an impression would be created amongst Hindus that pro-Khalistan feelings were catching the imagination of all Sikhs, both in Punjab and abroad, which had the potential of endangering the integrity of the nation.

In such a vitiated atmosphere, Hindus were expected to feel hurt, victimized and threatened by the acts of the Sikh community, whose interests could easily be ignored as they comprised less than 2 per cent of the country's population. Prolonged and unhindered but carefully controlled discontent among members of the majority community was expected to generate emotional hysteria and the